BETWEEN THE LINES

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OPENING

"Our trucks are more connected than they've ever been. They've got over a hundred points of connectivity." That line from NMFTA's Joe Ohr at this month's cybersecurity conference captures where trucking sits right now [Transport Topics]. Capacity is tightening, diesel topped $6.41 a gallon, and the FMCSA is still trying to stabilize Motus [Transport Topics][FreightWaves]. Inside this issue: why intermodal is quietly stealing truckload share, a fresh wave of driver pay hikes, Kodiak's year-end driverless launch with IKEA, and the regulatory stories your safety team can't miss.

THE BIG STORY

Rejection rates won't quit. Diesel won't retreat. And the market feels tight for reasons that have little to do with surging demand.

The freight market turned, and capacity discipline is doing most of the work

Tender rejection rates are stuck near 14% heading into what's historically one of the softest stretches of the fourth quarter, and that stickiness is the real story of the month [FreightWaves]. Normally the first two weeks of October bring a lull. This year, flatbed and reefer rejections are edging higher, and dry van is only showing a modest seasonal dip. Something structural has changed.

14%
TRUCKLOAD TENDER REJECTION RATE HOLDING INTO Q4

8%
YEAR-OVER-YEAR GROWTH IN DOMESTIC

$6.41
AVERAGE DIESEL PRICE PER GALLON, NEAR RECORD

10¢
PER-MILE PAY BUMP AT ANDERSON TRUCKING SERVICE

INTERMODAL
VOLUMES

FreightWaves analyst Zach Strickland was careful not to call it a demand boom, and he's right to hedge. Domestic intermodal volumes just hit all-time highs, running 8% above last year, which means a chunk of what would have moved by truck is riding the rails instead [FreightWaves]. Strip that out and the underlying truckload demand picture looks softer than the rejection numbers suggest. What's keeping capacity tight is the supply side: enforcement crackdowns on CDL mills, English language proficiency checks, non-domiciled CDL restrictions, and three straight years of shrinking driver supply [Trucking Dive].

> *"Our trucks are more connected than they've ever been. They've got over a hundred points of connectivity. The attack surface continues to grow."*
>
> Joe Ohr, Chief Operating Officer, NMFTA

Carriers are responding the way you'd expect when the leverage finally shifts. Anderson Trucking Service raised flatbed pay 10 cents a mile to 70 cents, matching an identical bump for its dry van drivers earlier in September [Trucking Dive]. Nussbaum, Roehl, and Averitt have all moved. On earnings calls, J.B. Hunt and Schneider executives said they're bringing back sign-on bonuses and funding targeted pay increases where customers want capacity badly enough to pay for it [Trucking Dive].

Diesel is the complicating variable. With Brent crude bouncing around $100 and the Iran conflict dragging into its eighth month, pump prices hit records and spot rates across every mode are inflating on fuel pass-through alone [Transport Topics][FreightWaves]. Smaller fleets with heavy spot exposure are watching margins compress because they can't recover the full fuel cost. The ISM manufacturing PMI held at 54.5 in September, a ninth straight month of expansion, which historically pulls LTL tonnage up about three months later [FreightWaves]. That's the setup heading into Q4: constrained supply, firming industrial demand, fuel-driven rate inflation, and a driver market that finally has pricing power.

QUICK TAKES

What else moved the market this month.

REGULATION

FMCSA says Motus user fixes are weeks away, back-end repairs will take longer

Deputy Administrator Jesse Elison told NMFTA's cybersecurity conference that the front-end user experience for the troubled Motus registration system should be fixed in a matter of weeks, though back-end stabilization will stretch on [FreightWaves]. FMCSA has already temporarily suspended enforcement of biennial updates and the related DOT number deactivations for carriers whose registration came due after June 1. Elison acknowledged the May launch was "really really tough" and that every early fix seemed to make things worse.

REGULATION

NHTSA resets fuel economy standards to 34.9 mpg by 2031

Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy and NHTSA finalized a rule rolling back CAFE standards, which the agency says will cut the average new vehicle price by roughly $1,300 and prevent 300,000 serious injuries over five years [Transportation Today]. Environmental groups counter that drivers will pay more at the pump and face more pollution. For fleet buyers of light-duty support vehicles, the practical effect is more model flexibility from OEMs and a slower pace of mandated efficiency gains.

DRIVERS

Samsara launches a free national driver perks program

Samsara's new Driver Perks platform gives professional drivers free discounts from more than 50 brands, from 24 Hour Fitness to Truck Parking Club, at no cost to drivers or their employers [FreightWaves]. Tens of thousands of drivers hit the site within weeks of launch. The real signal here is what drivers asked for in surveys: fitness, audiobooks, travel, and portable grills ranked ahead of convenience items, pointing to how retention conversations are shifting toward off-road well-being.

TECH

Kodiak sets year-end driverless launch with IKEA on the Dallas-Houston lane

Kodiak will remove the safety driver from its IKEA runs between Houston and Frisco by the end of 2026, backed by a new PrePass integration that feeds pre-trip inspection data directly to roadside enforcement [FreightWaves][Trucking Dive]. Under CVSA's enhanced inspection standard for autonomous trucks, each unit must pass what amounts to an annual-level inspection every four days, with zero defects allowed. Four years of safety-driver operations on the same lane and nearly 4 million autonomous miles anchor the launch.

LABOR

Senate confirms Keith Sonderling as Labor Secretary

The Senate confirmed Sonderling 47-41 on September 30, elevating the acting secretary to the permanent role after Lori Chavez-DeRemer's abrupt departure in April [Transport Topics]. Sonderling has already served in multiple Labor Department roles and as a Republican EEOC commissioner. For fleets, the near-term watch items are overtime enforcement, independent contractor classification, and how the department handles education grant programs transferred from DOE.

FUEL

States move to blunt fuel price pain at the pump

Roughly a third of U.S. states have enacted some form of fuel tax relief as diesel hovers near record highs [Transport Topics]. Ohio passed a 90-day gas and diesel tax holiday, Georgia reinstated its fuel tax break through late October, and nine states loosened dyed diesel rules so farmers can run tax-exempt fuel on highways during harvest. Convenience store operators warn relief won't show up at the pump instantly, since taxes are collected upstream.

WHAT TO WATCH

Stories worth tracking into next month.

M&A

CMA CGM closes $1.4B FedEx Supply Chain deal, nearly tripling CEVA's U.S. footprint

CMA CGM finalized the FedEx Supply Chain acquisition, adding 34 million square feet of warehouse space, 150 facilities, and 20,000 workers to its CEVA logistics arm [The Loadstar]. FedEx becomes a preferred ocean carrier partner in return. Expect CEVA to become a more aggressive bidder for contract logistics and final-mile work in North America over the next year.

RATES

LTL carriers head into earnings season with firming yields

Old Dominion reports Q3 on October 28 and has already flagged accelerating year-over-year yield growth with and without fuel surcharges [FreightWaves]. Several carriers pulled their general rate increases forward. With ISM manufacturing in a ninth straight month of expansion, the setup favors continued LTL recovery into Q1 2027, barring a surprise consumer pullback.

FRAUD

Cloned-load thefts and driver-pay suits put compliance teams on notice

Cook County investigators intercepted a $60,000 glycerin shipment after criminals cloned the paperwork and redirected 75 drums toward a cross-dock [FreightWaves]. Separately, a proposed class action against Michigan-based Red Line Logistics alleges the carrier ran two TMS platforms to hide actual freight revenue from owner-operators [FreightWaves]. Both stories point to the same thing: verification processes and settlement transparency are now compliance-grade concerns.

THE BOTTOM LINE

October's data says the market has turned, but the turn is being built on discipline rather than a demand surge. Carriers that invested in driver pay, cleaned up compliance, and leaned into technology are the ones with pricing power now. The fleets that will carry that momentum into 2027 are the ones treating recruiting, retention, and regulatory readiness as the same project. Tight capacity rewards operators who are ready to run.

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SOURCES ▲

Compiled 2026-10-01 from 8 publications over the past 30 days.

DC Velocity

> 2026-09-30 Nearly half of service robots sold in 2025 were used for transportation & logistics

2026-09-30 UPS launches “secure commerce” service to guard against fraud

2026-09-29 Port of Savannah is 60% done with $1.6 billion expansion

2026-09-29 Echo Global Logistics ties up acquisitions ITS and Roadtex into a single unit

2026-09-28 U.S. Bank launches financial service arm for manufacturers

2026-09-28 Trade group criticizes California laws regulating cold chain warehouses

2026-09-28 Trust, Cost, and the AI-Native Warehouse

2026-09-28 Survey: AI-powered shift scheduling tool can help both employees and managers

2026-09-28 Banyan Technology uses AI to predict late shipments

2026-09-28 NRF: Retail sales rose modestly in August

FreightWaves

2026-10-01 Free Driver Rewards Program? Samsara Targets Retention

2026-10-01 Intermodal Hits All-Time Highs as Truckload Stays Tight

2026-10-01 IKEA Picks Kodiak for Driverless Freight Rollout

2026-10-01 Transportation provider accused of hiding freight revenue from owner-operators

2026-10-01 FMCSA’s Elison: ‘weeks’ away from fixing Motus user experience

2026-10-01 September’s 54.5 manufacturing PMI comes with inflation concerns

2026-10-01 Alaska Air eyes 50% share of intra-island Hawaii cargo market

2026-10-01 New California law clouds Trump-backed Oakland coal export terminal project

2026-10-01 Thieves clone $60K shipment, redirect 41,000 pounds of glycerin in Illinois

2026-10-01 White Paper: State of the Industry – October 2026

Supply Chain Dive

2026-10-01 Walmart to build Ohio fulfillment center for oversized goods

2026-09-30 Not just ocean: How Maersk grew its US logistics capabilities

2026-09-30 Sustainable fast fashion: paradox or possibility?

2026-09-30 Mars hikes sustainably sourced cocoa but falls short of 2025 100% goal

2026-09-30 Amazon rolls out new capabilities for bulky package shippers

2026-09-30 USPS, Amazon partner on same-day delivery pilot

2026-09-29 Ross plans 1.75M-square-foot distribution center in California

2026-09-29 Electrolux appoints chief procurement officer

2026-09-29 3 CPGs discuss automation, sourcing and logistics risks

2026-09-29 Nordstrom eyes weekend delivery, faster shipping

The Loadstar

2026-10-01 CMA CGM completes $1.4bn FedEx Supply Chain takeover

2026-10-01 Premier Alliance prepares for Asia-N Europe services return to Suez

2026-10-01 WiseTech air cargo push challenges independent booking platforms

2026-10-01 Military aid prompts Thai Airways u-turn on cargo booking embargo

2026-10-01 Investment in China’s river ports brings ocean services closer to shippers

2026-10-01 Breaking up DSV and Kuehne is hard to do. However…

2026-10-01 Holiday shopping sprees set to increase – but without delivery headaches?

2026-10-01 Air cargo gains ground with shippers, but concerns remain on waybill changes

2026-09-30 Hormuz closure a fatal blow for Dubai and Abu Dhabi transhipment volumes

2026-09-30 Hapag-Lloyd’s Zim takeover hopes dealt fresh blow as review halted

Transport Advancement

2026-10-01 Siemens, OMV Deploy SICHARGE FLEX Charging System in Austria

2026-09-28 Digitalizing Customs Speeding Up Cargo Clearance Solutions

2026-09-28 Modular Design Scaling Terminal Expansion Projects

2026-09-28 Integrating Last Mile Drones into Modern Global Cargo Hubs

2026-09-28 Resilient Infrastructure Strengthening Global Mega Hubs

2026-09-28 Enhancing Cold Chain Logistics in Shipping Operations

2026-09-28 Improving Throughput With AI Driven Scheduling Systems

2026-09-28 Rise of Autonomous Cargo Handling Systems in Logistics

2026-09-25 Vietnam, Germany to Strengthen High-Speed Rail Cooperation

2026-09-23 Malaysia, China Deepen Transport Sector Cooperation

Transport Topics

2026-10-01 NMFTA warns trucking of skillful cybersecurity escalation

2026-10-01 Tesla EV deliveries set to drop on weak demand, aging lineup

2026-10-01 Canada fast-tracks West Coast oil pipeline

2026-10-01 Trimble still evaluating possible transport tech business sale

2026-10-01 Oil prices waver around $100 as 7-month Iran war continues

2026-10-01 U.S. pressures EU to release strategic fuel reserves

2026-10-01 High gas prices are spurring states to waive fuel taxes

2026-10-01 Senate approves Keith Sonderling to lead Labor Department

2026-10-01 Trump forced-labor tariffs face skeptical trade court

2026-09-30 Trucking must rethink workflows as AI expands, Trimble CEO says

Transportation Today News

- 2026-09-30 Trump administration resets fuel economy standards
- 2026-09-30 Research offers approaches to strengthen rail safety, resilience
- 2026-09-30 Hudson Tunnel Project begins tunnel boring
- 2026-09-30 Legislation introduced to invest in American airports, air traffic control
- 2026-09-29 FAA awards $84.4M in airport improvement grants to Texas, N.C., Wyoming
- 2026-09-29 Traffic fatalities down for the fourth year, but still up over the decade: TRIP report
- 2026-09-29 N.C. Railroad Company president and CEO steps down
- 2026-09-29 USDOT announces winners for ARPA-I Ideas and Innovation Challenge
- 2026-09-28 MassDOT board of directors approves three projects
- 2026-09-28 Pennsylvania begins work on more than 400 miles of “Rapid Deployment Projects”

Trucking Dive

- 2026-10-01 Circle Logistics targets food and beverage shippers in reefer LTL service expansion
- 2026-09-30 Businessman allegedly bilked trucking investors of $105.9M
- 2026-09-30 Amazon rolls out new capabilities for bulky package shippers
- 2026-09-30 Trucking fleets repurpose diesel tractors with swappable electric batteries
- 2026-09-30 Anderson Trucking raising pay for flatbed drivers by 10 cents per mile
- 2026-09-29 Kodiak targets year-end driverless launch on Dallas-Houston lane with Ikea
- 2026-09-29 Bulk carrier constraints pinch multiple markets
- 2026-09-28 Old Dominion Freight Line names new board member
- 2026-09-28 Kodiak AI partners with PrePass to enhance inspection process
- 2026-09-28 Shippers are exploring port-to-inland transit to de-risk supply chains